



AI GUIDE SERIES · BOOK TWO

AI for Everyday Life

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AI for Everyday Life

*50 Practical Ways to Save Time, Solve Problems,
and Think Better with AI*

AI Guide Series - Book 2

Patrick Thomas

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First published in 2026

Content last reviewed: August 2026

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Artificial intelligence systems can produce inaccurate, incomplete, outdated, biased, misleading, or fabricated information. Review AI-generated material and verify important claims with current, authoritative sources. AI can assist your thinking, but it cannot accept responsibility for your decisions.

Product references are illustrative and do not constitute endorsements. Privacy controls and data-handling practices vary by product and account. Review the current terms and settings before entering personal, confidential, or regulated information.

Table of Contents

Introduction: The Tool Nobody Taught You	1
Chapter 1: Choosing Your AI Assistant	3
Chapter 2: Talking to AI Like a Human	5
Chapter 3: Saving Time at Home	7
Chapter 4: Using AI at Work	11
Chapter 5: Learning Faster with AI	14
Chapter 6: Making Better Decisions with AI	16
Chapter 7: Staying Safe with AI	18
Conclusion: A Useful Place to Begin	21

Introduction: The Tool Nobody Taught You

Artificial intelligence appears in the news, at work, in schools, and inside products people already use. Yet many people have never been shown how to use an AI assistant for an ordinary problem.

That is the purpose of this book.

You do not need to write code or understand computer science. You need to describe what you want, provide the details that matter, and judge whether the answer is useful and reliable.

AI can help draft an email, organize a meal plan, explain an unfamiliar term, structure a project, prepare questions, or compare options. It can reduce the effort involved in routine thinking and give you a starting point when a blank page feels intimidating.

It can also be wrong. A polished answer may be incomplete, outdated, or invented. Some AI products can search current sources or use external tools, but those features do not guarantee accuracy. Use AI to begin work, not to end your judgment.

A Useful Mental Model

Many modern AI assistants generate responses by recognizing and extending patterns learned from large collections of data. The scale of that pattern recognition can produce language that feels thoughtful and informed. Fluency, however, is not proof of understanding or accuracy.

Capabilities also differ by product, plan, location, and date. Some assistants can browse the web, analyze files, create images, or connect to other applications. Others cannot. Check what the specific tool can access before assuming its answer is current.

How to Use This Book

The fifty applications are numbered so you can track the promise on the cover. You can read them in order or turn directly to the problem you want to solve.

Most applications include a copy-ready prompt. Replace the bracketed text with your own information. Whenever possible, use approximate or anonymized details instead of names, account numbers, medical identifiers, or confidential records.

Every useful AI habit has three parts:

- 1 Ask clearly.
- 2 Review carefully.
- 3 Verify according to the risk.

The higher the stakes, the stronger the verification should be.

Chapter 1: Choosing Your AI Assistant

The best first AI assistant is one you can access, understand, and use safely. Popular options include ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, and Microsoft Copilot. They overlap, but they are not interchangeable. Features, integrations, usage limits, privacy controls, and prices change frequently.

Instead of trying to crown a permanent winner, compare the products using durable questions:

- Does it work on the devices you use?
- Can it handle the type of task you have in mind?
- Can it search current sources when current information matters?
- Does it provide links or citations you can inspect?
- What happens to the information you enter?
- Does your employer permit it for work?
- Is the free tier sufficient, or would a paid plan solve a real limitation?

Microsoft also uses the Copilot name for different experiences. A general chat product is not the same as paid Copilot features integrated into Word, Outlook, Teams, or other Microsoft 365 applications. Read the current product description before paying.

Start with a free plan if one meets your needs. Upgrade only after you can name the limitation you are trying to remove. Consult each provider's official site for current prices and features.

Begin with a Low-Risk Task

Do not start with a diagnosis, tax decision, legal deadline, confidential work file, or major purchase. Start with a task whose result you can easily judge, such as rewriting a paragraph or organizing a weekend checklist.

Try this opening:

I am new to AI assistants. Give me three low-risk practice tasks that will help me learn how to give clear instructions, review an answer, and ask a useful follow-up question.

Use Search and AI Together

An AI assistant can explain and organize. A search engine or official website can help you locate current evidence. Use the tool that fits the task.

For a stable, low-risk explanation, AI may be enough for a first draft. For prices, laws, benefits, schedules, health guidance, product specifications, or current events, find and inspect current sources. Ask the AI to help you understand those sources rather than replacing them.

Common Beginner Mistakes

- Asking a vague question and expecting a specific answer
- Trusting confidence instead of checking evidence
- Sharing more personal information than the task requires
- Giving up after one weak response instead of clarifying the goal
- Using AI when an official source, calculator, or qualified professional is the better tool

Chapter 2: Talking to AI Like a Human

You do not need secret commands. Good prompting is clear communication.

A useful request usually contains five elements:

- Goal: what you want to accomplish
- Context: the facts that affect the answer
- Constraints: limits such as time, budget, length, or tone
- Format: how you want the result presented
- Verification: what the answer should flag for independent checking

Everyday Use #1: Turn a Vague Request into a Clear One

Instead of writing "chicken recipe," explain what you have and what would make the result useful.

I have chicken breast, broccoli, rice, and soy sauce. Create a healthy dinner for two that takes less than 30 minutes. Keep the steps simple for a beginner and list any food-safety temperatures I should verify with an authoritative source.

Everyday Use #2: Ask the AI to Interview You First

When you are unsure what information matters, let the assistant ask focused questions.

I want help with [task], but I am not sure how to describe what I need. Ask me up to five questions, one at a time. Then restate my goal and write a clear prompt I can approve before you answer it.

Everyday Use #3: Request the Format You Need

The same information can be a checklist, table, timeline, email, script, or short explanation.

Explain [topic] for [audience]. Present it as a one-page checklist with short action steps, a section called "What to verify," and no unexplained jargon.

Everyday Use #4: Improve a Weak First Answer

The first response is a draft. Tell the assistant what missed the mark.

Revise your last answer. Keep [what worked]. Change [what did not work]. Make it more useful for [audience or situation], and do not add facts that were not in my original material.

Everyday Use #5: Ask for Assumptions and Uncertainty

AI often fills gaps silently. Make those gaps visible.

Before finalizing this answer, list the assumptions you made, the parts you are least certain about, and the claims I should verify independently. Then give me the revised answer.

About Roles

You can ask for the perspective of an editor, teacher, travel planner, project manager, or career coach. This can shape tone and priorities, but it does not give the system credentials.

For example, ask for the perspective of an experienced travel planner, then state the destination, budget, and facts that need current verification. Do not treat "act as a doctor," "act as a lawyer," or "act as a financial adviser" as a substitute for professional advice. A role changes the framing of a response, not the system's qualifications.

Chapter 3: Saving Time at Home

Household work includes planning, remembering, organizing, comparing, and preparing. AI can reduce some of that mental load, provided you keep safety and privacy in view.

Everyday Use #6: Plan Several Dinners

Create five dinners using [ingredients]. Each meal should serve [number], take less than [time], and fit [preferences or allergies]. Reuse ingredients to reduce waste. Separate general ideas from any nutrition or allergy claims that require verification.

Everyday Use #7: Cook from What You Have

I have [ingredients]. Suggest three meals I can make without another shopping trip, ranked from easiest to most involved. Ask about allergies before suggesting substitutions.

Everyday Use #8: Turn a Meal Plan into a Grocery List

Convert this meal plan into a grocery list organized by produce, protein, dairy, frozen, and pantry items. Combine duplicate ingredients and show estimated quantities for [number] people: [meal plan].

Everyday Use #9: Build a Realistic Cleaning Routine

Create a cleaning routine for a [size] home. I can spend [time] per day. Separate daily, weekly, monthly, and seasonal tasks. Keep each daily session small enough to finish.

Everyday Use #10: Create a Home-Maintenance Calendar

Create a general month-by-month home-maintenance checklist for a [home type] in [climate or region]. Include filters, alarms, plumbing, exterior checks, and seasonal preparation. Clearly label tasks that require manufacturer instructions, local rules, or a qualified technician.

Everyday Use #11: Prepare for a Repair Call

Use AI to organize observations, not to take risks.

My [appliance or system] is doing this: [symptoms]. Help me write a clear description for a repair professional. List only low-risk observations I can make without opening panels, bypassing safety devices, touching wiring, handling refrigerant, or working around gas, fire, structural damage, or moving machinery. Tell me which warning signs mean I should stop and call for help immediately.

Everyday Use #12: Plan a Beginner Home Project

Help me plan this project: [project]. Create a materials list, preparation checklist, sequence of work, cleanup plan, and questions to ask before starting. Identify permits, electrical, plumbing, structural, ladder, chemical, or protective-equipment issues that require official guidance or professional help.

Everyday Use #13: Organize Household Records

Design a simple filing system for insurance documents, tax records, medical records, warranties, manuals, and identity documents. Suggest categories and a review schedule. Do not ask me to paste document contents or identifying numbers into this chat.

Everyday Use #14: Prepare for a Medical Appointment

I have an appointment about [general concern]. Help me prepare a concise symptom timeline, a medication-and-supplement checklist, and questions to ask the clinician. Do not diagnose the condition. Include urgent warning signs that should be handled through emergency or immediate medical care rather than waiting for the appointment.

Everyday Use #15: Translate Medical Language

Explain this medical term in plain language: [term]. Describe its general meaning, questions I might ask my clinician, and which parts depend on my personal history or test results. Do not interpret my records or recommend treatment.

Everyday Use #16: Build a General Wellness Routine

AI can suggest general habits, but it should not prescribe exercise around pain or injury.

Help me build a general wellness routine around [sleep, movement, stress, or another goal]. I have [time] available. Keep the suggestions low-risk and realistic. If my situation includes pain, injury, pregnancy, medication, severe symptoms, or a health condition, tell me what to discuss with a licensed clinician before changing my routine.

Everyday Use #17: Design a Habit System

I want to build these habits: [list]. Create a simple routine using small starting actions, visible reminders, and a weekly review. Limit the plan to [time] per day and include a recovery step for missed days.

Everyday Use #18: Plan an Event

Help me plan a [event] for about [number] guests on [date or timeframe] with a budget of approximately [amount]. Create a timeline, checklist, quantity estimates, accessibility questions, backup plan, and items whose current prices or venue rules I must verify.

Everyday Use #19: Understand a Government Benefit

Explain [program] in plain language using current official government sources. Cover its purpose, general eligibility, application steps, deadlines, and documents commonly requested. Link directly to the official agency pages and identify anything that varies by location or date. Do not decide whether I qualify.

Everyday Use #20: Prepare for a Caregiving Conversation

I help care for a family member with [general condition]. Without diagnosing or recommending treatment, help me organize day-to-day observations and questions for the care team. Include caregiver-support topics, medication questions, and warning signs that require immediate professional or emergency help. Do not ask for names, record numbers, or identifiable medical documents.

Chapter 4: Using AI at Work

AI can assist with routine communication and organization, leaving more time for work that depends on judgment, experience, leadership, and relationships. Before using it, learn your organization's rules and approved tools.

Never paste confidential business information, proprietary data, private employee or customer information, passwords, security credentials, or regulated records into a public AI assistant. When possible, replace names and exact figures with roles, ranges, or placeholders.

Everyday Use #21: Draft a Professional Email

Draft a professional email to [role, not name]. The situation is [sanitized summary]. My goal is [result]. Use a [tone] tone and keep it under [length]. Leave placeholders wherever a confidential detail would be needed.

Everyday Use #22: Revise Tone and Clarity

Revise this message for clarity and tone. Put the main request first, remove unnecessary words, and preserve every factual detail. Do not invent commitments, dates, or explanations: [sanitized draft].

Everyday Use #23: Build a Meeting Agenda

Create a [duration] meeting agenda from these non-confidential topics: [topics]. The desired outcome is [outcome]. Include time estimates, decisions needed, and a final action-item review.

Everyday Use #24: Organize Meeting Notes

Organize these sanitized notes into decisions, action items, owners, deadlines, open questions, and a short summary. Mark missing owners or dates as "not provided" instead of guessing: [notes].

Everyday Use #25: Structure a Report or Summary

Create an outline for a [report type] for [audience]. Use these approved, non-confidential facts: [facts]. Separate evidence, interpretation, risks, and recommended next steps. Identify gaps rather than filling them in.

Everyday Use #26: Draft a Project Plan

Create a first-draft project plan for [sanitized project]. Include phases, milestones, dependencies, decision points, owners as roles, risks, and a suggested timeline. Label every assumption.

Everyday Use #27: Generate a Risk Checklist

AI can help generate possibilities, but it cannot assure that a project is safe or complete.

Review this sanitized plan and generate a preliminary risk checklist. Group risks by people, schedule, cost, operations, security, compliance, and dependencies. Ask questions where information is missing. Do not claim the review is complete: [plan].

Everyday Use #28: Create a Procedure or Checklist

Draft a checklist for [routine task] using only the approved steps I provide. Write for a new employee, preserve required warnings, and flag any missing approval or safety step: [approved steps].

Everyday Use #29: Brainstorm Possible Solutions

Generate ten possible approaches to this sanitized problem: [problem]. Include conventional and unconventional options. For each, give one likely advantage, one drawback, and one fact that must be checked before adoption.

Everyday Use #30: Prepare for a Difficult Conversation

Help me prepare for a conversation with [role]. The issue is [sanitized description], their likely perspective is [perspective], and my goal is [goal]. Suggest a respectful opening, questions to ask, points to cover, and reactions I should avoid. Do not impersonate the other person or make assumptions about protected characteristics.

Chapter 5: Learning Faster with AI

An AI assistant can explain a concept in several ways, create practice questions, and adjust the difficulty of a lesson. It can also teach something incorrectly. Anchor important learning to a trustworthy course, textbook, manual, or official source.

Everyday Use #31: Build a Learning Plan

Create a 30-day beginner plan for learning [skill]. I can practice [time] on [days]. Include weekly goals, small exercises, a final project, and reliable sources I can use to check the instruction.

Everyday Use #32: Request a Plain-Language Explanation

Explain [topic] for someone with no background in it. Define necessary terms, use one concrete example, identify common misunderstandings, and tell me which claims I should check in a current authoritative source.

Everyday Use #33: Break a Large Subject into Lessons

Break [subject] into ten beginner lessons. Show me the roadmap first. Teach one lesson at a time and wait for me before continuing. End each lesson with a short retrieval question.

Everyday Use #34: Learn a New Device or Application

Teach me how to perform [task] in [device or application and version]. Start with the basics and use numbered steps. Warn me when menus may differ by version, and direct me to the official help page for current instructions.

Everyday Use #35: Create a Practice Quiz

Quiz me on [topic] using material from [named source or pasted non-copyrighted notes]. Ask one question at a time. After I answer, explain the reasoning and point back to the source. If the source does not answer the question, say so rather than guessing.

Everyday Use #36: Learn Through Self-Explanation

Explaining an idea in your own words can expose gaps that rereading hides.

Give me a short explanation of [topic], then ask me to explain it back in my own words. Compare my explanation with the reliable source I provide, identify gaps, and give me one follow-up question. Do not treat your own earlier answer as independent evidence.

Everyday Use #37: Explore Several Viewpoints

Help me understand [issue] from at least three well-supported viewpoints. For each, explain its strongest argument, evidence, assumptions, and limitations. Distinguish factual disagreement from disagreement about values, and provide sources I can inspect.

Chapter 6: Making Better Decisions with AI

AI can organize options and surface questions. It cannot know everything that matters to you, remain perfectly neutral, or accept the consequences of a decision. It may also agree too readily with the way you framed the problem.

Keep the decision human.

Everyday Use #38: Clarify the Decision

Help me clarify a decision without choosing for me. Ask questions one at a time. Then summarize my options, priorities, constraints, unknowns, and the people affected. Mark any assumption you introduced.

Everyday Use #39: Build a Criteria Matrix

Create a comparison table for [options]. Use these criteria that I selected: [criteria]. Ask me to assign the importance of each criterion. Do not choose weights for me. Show where current data or professional advice is needed.

Everyday Use #40: Conduct a Pre-Mortem

Assume I chose [option] and, one year later, the result was disappointing. Generate plausible reasons, early warning signs, and preventive steps. Separate likely risks from speculative ones.

Everyday Use #41: Challenge Your Assumptions

I am leaning toward [position]. Identify the assumptions behind my preference. Present the strongest evidence-based case against it, then list what new information would reasonably change my mind.

Everyday Use #42: Build a Privacy-Safe Budget Draft

Using approximate monthly ranges rather than account details, help me create a simple budget template. My income range is [range], and my expense categories are [categories]. Do not request account numbers, employer details, tax documents, or identifying information. Suggest questions for a qualified adviser if the situation involves debt, taxes, investing, retirement, or insolvency.

Everyday Use #43: Prepare for a Major Financial or Medical Conversation

I am preparing to discuss [retirement, debt, surgery, treatment, or another high-stakes issue] with a qualified professional. Help me organize my goals, concerns, questions, and documents to bring. Do not recommend a decision, diagnose a condition, interpret personal records, or estimate an outcome.

Everyday Use #44: Evaluate a Career Change

Help me compare my current role with a possible move into [field]. Consider skills, training time, financial transition, job conditions, growth, work-life fit, and uncertainty. Use current labor sources where possible and identify local facts I must verify. Do not assume that salary or job availability is current without evidence.

Chapter 7: Staying Safe with AI

Scammers use fear, urgency, secrecy, authority, affection, and promised rewards to push people into acting before they verify. AI can make an impersonation more convincing, but the defensive habits remain practical: pause, use a channel you choose, protect information, and confirm independently.

Everyday Use #45: Examine a Suspicious Message Safely

Do not paste names, phone numbers, account details, links, tracking codes, or other identifying information into a public AI assistant. AI can identify possible warning signs, but it cannot certify that a message is safe.

Analyze this redacted message for possible manipulation or fraud. Identify urgency, secrecy, unusual payment requests, credential requests, impersonation, and claims that require independent verification. Do not tell me it is safe. Recommend how I can contact the organization using a number or website I locate myself: [redacted message].

Everyday Use #46: Verify a Voice-Clone Emergency

A familiar voice is no longer proof of identity.

Help my family create a verification plan for emergency calls. Include a private code word, calling the person back at a known number, contacting another trusted person, and refusing payment until identity and circumstances are confirmed. Do not rely on personal trivia that may be available online.

If anyone may be in immediate physical danger, contact emergency services through an official number. Do not delay urgent safety action merely to satisfy a waiting period.

Everyday Use #47: Recognize Dangerous Payment Requests

Someone asking you to buy gift cards and provide the card number or PIN is attempting a scam. Government agencies and legitimate businesses do not require gift cards as payment. Wire transfers, cryptocurrency, payment apps, and remote-computer access also deserve special caution when requested unexpectedly.

Create a one-page family reminder about unusual payment requests. Include gift cards, wire transfers, cryptocurrency, payment apps, remote access, secrecy, and instructions to verify through a known official channel before sending anything.

Everyday Use #48: Investigate a Claim

Help me investigate this claim: [claim]. Break it into checkable statements, identify the best primary or official sources, note the date of the evidence, and distinguish confirmed facts from inference. Do not treat repeated claims or AI-generated citations as independent confirmation.

Everyday Use #49: Examine Persuasion and Missing Context

Analyze this redacted message or excerpt for emotional pressure, selective evidence, missing context, unsupported conclusions, and conflicts of interest. Identify questions I should ask and sources I should inspect. Do not infer the author's identity or intent without evidence: [text].

Everyday Use #50: Run a Privacy Check Before You Share

Create a pre-sharing checklist for information I might enter into an AI assistant. Cover personal identifiers, financial data, medical information, confidential work material, information about other people, security credentials, location details, and organization policy. Suggest safer placeholders or summaries for each category.

A Short Safety Checklist

Pause and verify independently if even one serious warning sign appears:

- An unexpected demand for money, credentials, verification codes, or remote access
- A request to buy gift cards or provide their numbers
- Pressure to keep the situation secret
- Threats, panic, or a demand to act before you can check
- A link, phone number, or payment instruction supplied by the sender
- A surprising voice, image, or video presented as proof

Use a website, phone number, or contact method you find independently. Do not use the suspicious message's link or callback number. If money or information has already been sent, contact the relevant bank, payment provider, account provider, or official reporting agency promptly.

Conclusion: A Useful Place to Begin

You do not need to use AI every day, adopt every new product, or turn every task into a conversation with a machine. The goal is not more AI. The goal is less friction, clearer thinking, and better-prepared human decisions.

Choose one low-risk application from this book. Try the prompt with non-sensitive information. Review the result. Verify anything important. Keep the workflow only if it provides a real benefit.

Human qualities remain central: experience, judgment, accountability, empathy, curiosity, and trust. AI can help organize words and possibilities. You decide what deserves attention and what should happen next.

A 30-Day Starting Plan

Week 1: Practice with low-risk writing and organization tasks.

Week 2: Improve prompts by adding context, constraints, format, and verification.

Week 3: Try one home, work, or learning workflow and measure whether it saves time or improves clarity.

Week 4: Keep only the useful workflows. Write down what must remain private, what requires verification, and when a professional or official source is the better choice.

Help me create a private, low-risk 30-day AI practice plan. Ask about my goals without requesting names, exact addresses, account details, medical records, confidential work information, or information about other people. Include one short exercise per day, a verification habit, and a weekly review.

Sources and Further Reading

These current, authoritative resources are useful starting points. Product features, prices, laws, and guidance may change, so confirm the date before acting.

NIST AI Risk Management Framework

<https://www.nist.gov/itl/ai-risk-management-framework>

NIST Generative Artificial Intelligence Profile

<https://doi.org/10.6028/NIST.AI.600-1>

Federal Trade Commission: Avoiding and Reporting Gift Card Scams

<https://consumer.ftc.gov/articles/avoiding-and-reporting-gift-card-scams>

Federal Trade Commission: Family Emergency Scams

<https://consumer.ftc.gov/articles/scammers-use-fake-emergencies-steal-your-money>

Internal Revenue Service: Tax Scams

<https://www.irs.gov/help/tax-scams>

Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency: Secure Our World

<https://www.cisa.gov/secure-our-world>

Official product information

<https://openai.com/chatgpt/pricing>

<https://www.anthropic.com/pricing>

<https://gemini.google.com>

<https://www.microsoft.com/microsoft-365/copilot>

About the Author

Patrick Thomas is an author, veteran, facilities management professional, and technology enthusiast focused on making artificial intelligence practical and approachable for everyday people.

His AI Guide Series offers clear explanations, useful examples, and responsible ways to apply AI at work, at home, while learning, and in everyday problem-solving.

Also in the AI Guide Series

- **Book 1 - AI Won't Replace You:** But Someone Using AI Might
- **Book 2 - AI for Everyday Life:** 50 Practical Ways to Save Time, Solve Problems, and Think Better with AI
- **Book 3 - AI at Work:** Increase Productivity and Get More Done Without Working Longer Hours
- **Book 4 - AI Safety and Scam Prevention:** Identify Scams, Spot Misinformation, and Stay Safe in an AI World
- **Book 5 - AI for Veterans:** Better Understand Benefits, Healthcare, and Government Services
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Build your AI skills one guide at a time.